

Fate's Edge

Amaranthine Worldbook

The Northern Shores and the Lands Beyond

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Part I

The World & Its Ways

Chapter 1

The Amaranthine Sea

The Amaranthine Sea lies at the heart of the known world, a salt expanse ringed by marble quays, vineyard hills, and smoke-blue mountains. For millennia it has served as the circulatory system of trade, faith, and conquest. Tides are subtle, but seasonal winds and river-feeds set the rhythm of commerce, pilgrimage, and war.

Unlike the dry southern coasts of distant lands, the wind patterns here reverse: the hot, arid air of the Sahel belt is pushed south, leaving the northern and eastern shores with ample rainfall and the southern shores as temperate grasslands. Thus the lands around the Amaranthine are lush and productive—olive groves in Ecktoria, wheat fields in Acasia, horse pastures on the Vilikari steppe.

North of the Amaranthine rise the Aelerian mountains, a spine of stone that separates the mild coastal lowlands from the colder northern reaches. Beyond those peaks lie the Violet Steppe and the Mistlands, where the Direwood presses against the fog-hung border. To the east, the Dolmis Sea (a dark inland basin) connects to the Amaranthine through the Astroegro Straits, guarded by the towers of Thepyrgos. The Aberderrin Sea, farther north, is a cold, wave-lashed expanse that borders both the Linn homelands and the Valewood.

A people without a single homeland, the Sidhi are a diaspora born from the ancient cities of Ashaan and Galanina. Their ships carry spice, silk, and secrets across every sea, and their enclaves thrive in Zakov, Kahfagia, and the port-towns of the Dolmis. Feared as pirates and respected as intermediaries, the Sidhi speak a dozen tongues and honor bargains with a blade if necessary. They are the frame through which many distant shores are glimpsed, though those shores lie beyond the scope of this book.

Chapter 2

Travel & Navigation

2.1 Core Travel Procedure

For each leg of a journey, draw 3–4 cards using the decks for your destination and controlling authority.

- ♠ from the destination deck: sets the scene (place).
- ♥ from the destination deck: introduces the local actor or faction.
- ♣ from the Wilds (general hazards) or destination (if strongly policed): brings pressure.
- ♦ from the authority that gates the route: papers, escorts, rights, or exceptions.

Set a travel clock by the highest rank:

- 2–5 $\Rightarrow$ 4 segments
- 6–10 $\Rightarrow$ 6 segments
- J/Q/K $\Rightarrow$ 8 segments
- A $\Rightarrow$ 10 segments

On success, advance to the next leg; on failure, mark delay, debt, or diversion and resolve a consequence in the fiction.

2.2 Mode Rules

2.2.1 Sea Legs

(Amaranthine/Dolmis/Aberderrin). If Theona or Valewood 9s show up anywhere in the seed, add an omission or taboo to the leg (a missing step, an unsaid name).

2.2.2 Passes & Underways

(Aeler). Any A may convert a surface route to an under-route. ♦ from Aeler always codifies outcomes—no roll—for sealed doors, breath time, and escorted segments.

2.2.3 Rivers

Bridges, booms, and law in Ecktoria/Viterra; reed-mazes and bell-lines in Mistlands/Linn waters.

2.2.4 Frontier Blends

When origin and destination disagree on law, draw two $\diamond$ (one from each law) and choose which you will be judged by at the end of the leg.

2.3 Regional Routes

2.3.1 Amaranthine Coastway

Kahfagia $\rightarrow$ Ecktoria $\rightarrow$ Acasia $\rightarrow$ Marcott (Vhasia) $\rightarrow$ Fairport (Viterra).

- Draw $\spadesuit+\heartsuit$ from the port you are entering.
- Draw $\clubsuit$ from the Wilds (gales, quarantine, harbor booms).
- Draw $\diamond$ from the port's deck (permits, berths), or Kahfagia if convoy/lantern law applies.

Silkstrand is Acasia's sole metropolis and a major trading hub; even land caravans risk the marches to reach it.

2.3.2 Astroegro Straits

Thepyrgos controls the hinge between seas via sentinel islands in the straits.

- Draw $\spadesuit+\heartsuit$ and $\clubsuit$ from Thepyrgos (stairs, boom, synod).
- Draw $\diamond$ from Thepyrgos (harbor pass, crane allotment).
- Switch to Dolmis/Amaranthine modules once the boom is lowered.

2.3.3 Dolmis Circuits

Fairport (Viterra) $\rightarrow$ Theona (Three Greens) $\rightarrow$ Ubral fjords $\rightarrow$ Aelinnel west shore $\rightarrow$ Zakov (north coast).

- $\spadesuit+\heartsuit$ from destination; $\clubsuit$ from Linn or the Wilds; $\diamond$ from Theona when island custom matters.
- Zakov: Draw $\spadesuit+\heartsuit$ from Zakov deck; $\clubsuit$ from Zakov or Linn; $\diamond$ from Zakov (harbor-green, corsair charter).

2.3.4 Aelerian Passes & Underways

Vhasia/Viterra/Ubral south slopes $\rightarrow$ Aeler gates $\rightarrow$ Mistlands.

- $\spadesuit+\heartsuit$ and $\clubsuit$ from Aeler; $\diamond$ from Aeler (Underway pass, Key-Writ, Breath time).

2.3.5 Shadow Corridors

Thin Shore (Valewood east coast): risky misted corridor north-south toward Zakov.

- $\spadesuit$ from Valewood, $\heartsuit$ from Mistlands (or Valewood), $\clubsuit$ from Mistlands (wraiths, bell-line failures), $\diamond$ from either Mistlands (Ward-salt, Lantern Writ) or Valewood (Way-cord, Truce-bough) depending on which law you invoke.
- *Rule of 9s*: any 9 in the seed adds an omission.

Green Gate hops (Aelinnel): tide-timed arches.

- $\spadesuit+\clubsuit$ from Aelinnel (tides, geasa), $\diamond$ from Aelinnel (Tide-path Key, Host-rights).

2.3.6 River Roads

Belworth: forms the boundary between Vhasia and Viterra. Twin ports at the mouth (Marcott and Fairport); at mid-reach Tarlington Falls requires lift/portage up to the plateau town. The Lence joins here from Vhasia. Use Viterra for east-bank audits/bridges, Vhasia for west-bank politics.

Yloka: raids run down from the north into the Aberderrin and Dolmis—overlay Linn ♣ and draw destination for ♠+♥.

Acasian rivers: hazardous but profitable approaches to Silkstrand; use Acasia ♣ (feuds/levies/curse) and ◇ (condotta, bridge rights).

2.3.7 Steppe Frontiers

Ykrul ↔ Vilikari ↔ Ecktoria/Acasia borders ↔ Black Banner territories.

- ♠ from the road you ride (Wolf Road or Foedus Stone), ♥ from the counterpart (envoys, comitatus), ♣ from Wilds or frontier decks (rasputitsa, hostage protocol, foedus recall), ◇ from either Ykrul (paiza, remounts) or Vilikari (foedus seal, bench-right).
- Black Banner: Draw ♠ from Ykrul/Vilikari decks (shared territory), ♥ from Black Banner, ♣ from Wilds or frontier decks, ◇ from Ykrul/Vilikari/Black Banner.

2.4 Gateways & Control Points

Gate	Deck	Diamond Source	Typical Leverage
Kassamira (Kahfagia)	Kahfagia	Kahfagia	Convoy letter; lantern-law warrant; pilotage token
Ecktoria Capital Port	Ecktoria	Ecktoria	Berth priority; coin-house credit; procession pennant
Silkstrand	Acasia	Acasia	Exchange floor; condotta; watergate priority
Marcott	Vhasia	Vhasia	Letters patent; safeconduct; fairground precedence
Fairport	Viterra	Viterra	Customs seal; ferry priority; Dawn escort
Tarlington Falls	Viterra	Viterra	Lift priority; bridge/portage pass; County Thing
Thepyrgos (boom)	Thepyrgos	Thepyrgos	Harbor pass; crane allotment; Synod indulgence
High-Mist Pass	Aeler	Aeler	Underway pass; Key-Writ; Breath time allotment
Payden's Port	Mistlands	Mistlands	Lantern writ; ward-salt; wraith indemnity
Thin Shore (Valewood)	Valewood	Valewood/Mistlands	Way-cord; dew-mirror; lantern writ
Green Gate (Aelinnel)	Aelinnel	Aelinnel	Tide-path key; host-right bough; salt license
Ubral Passes	Ubral	Aeler/Ubral	Vurim pass-ring; hill-fort shelter writ; guide's bribe
Thing-holm (Linn)	Linn	Linn	Thing ruling; harbor-green; escort writ
Foedus Stone (March)	Vilikari	Vilikari/Ykrul	Foedus renewal; remount allotment; hostage treaty
Zakov Roadstead	Zakov	Zakov	Harbor-green chit; corsair charter; pilot token
Black Banner Camps	Black Banner	Black Banner/Ykrul/Vilikari	Safe-conduct; remount chit; clan truce

Table 2.1: Gateway Control Points

2.5 Overlay: Gatekeepers (Zakov Roadstead & Harbour Quarters)

Draw **one** micro-card each time you *enter*, *shift wharfs*, or *depart* Zakov. Combine with the normal seed.

Zakov Gatekeepers Micro-Cards (draw 1)

1. **Bureaucrat Quirk** — stamps only at *eighth bell*; night filings need a *Night Magistrate* countersign.
2. **Required Stamp** — *Harbor-Green* chit for boom passage this tide; without it, DV +1 on all port checks.
3. **Preferred Gratuity** — figs or lamp oil; wrong gift offends, marking 1 *Exposure* on your port reputation.
4. **Audit Trap** — “contraband tallies”; if carrying *bell-metal* or *dyestuffs*, start a 4-seg *Inspection* clock.
5. **Local Courtesy** — speak the *Dock Oath* (short pledge not to knife on planks) or suffer *Desperate* position in brawls.
6. **Shortcut Rumor** — *Smuggler’s Ladder* on the sea wall; spend a ◇ (*Ladder Map*) to skip one queue.
7. **Pilot’s Privilege** — a *Pilot Token* bumps you ahead on boom lift; otherwise pay tow or lose 1 segment.
8. **Silent Court** — the *Black Bishop* is sitting tonight; legal ♣ escalate by +1 SB if you contest a ruling.

2.6 Special Rules & Taboos

2.6.1 Theona / Valewood 9s

Whenever a 9 appears in a seed involving Theona or Valewood, add an omission: a missing step, an unsaid name, an unseen guest. If the 9 is a ◇, you may break the taboo once—someone will come to collect.

2.6.2 Aeler Aces

An A can rewire routes beneath the mountains. You may swap your ♠ to Aeler (keeping the other seed cards) and continue under-vault procedures.

2.6.3 Echoing Omens

Any A adds a motif you can echo later (ash on the wind, a bell heard underground, a landmark that returns elsewhere). Make the world feel like it remembers.

2.7 Worked Itineraries

2.7.1 West-to-East Coastal Haul (Kahfagia → Viterra)

Leg 1: Kassamira → Ecktoria Seed:

Ecktoria ♠ (Aqueduct arcades), Ecktoria ♥ (Coin-house factor), Wilds ♣ (gale), Kahfagia ◇ (convoy letter).

Clock: 6. Read: cross under coin-house eyes with convoy priority; bad weather strains schedules.

Leg 2: Ecktoria → Silkstrand Seed:

Acasia ♠ (Three-Queens Bridge), Acasia ♥ (Dyers' Guildmistress), Acasia ♣ (loom strike), Acasia ♦ (Exchange pass).

Clock: 6–8 depending on unrest.

Leg 3: Silkstrand → Marcott Seed:

Vhasia ♠ (Pont-du-Tithe), Vhasia ♥ (Parlement clerk), Vhasia ♣ (coin rumor), Vhasia ♦ (letters patent).

Leg 4: Marcott → Fairport Seed:

Viterra ♠ (Fairport tideworks), Viterra ♥ (shipwright), Linn ♣ (boom lifts), Viterra ♦ (customs seal).

Clock: 6.

2.7.2 Acasia → Mistlands (Forgotten Pass + Under-Gate)

Leg 1: Silkstrand → Aeler Gate Seed:

Aeler ♠ (Avalanche gallery), Aeler ♥ (Geometer), Aeler ♣ (Engineer requisition), Aeler ♦ (Underway Pass).

Leg 2: Gate → Mistlands Seed:

Mistlands ♠ (Bell-Line levee), Mistlands ♥ (Bell-warden), Mistlands ♣ (wraith crossing), Mistlands ♦ (Ward-salt).

2.7.3 Thin Shore → Zakov Corridor

Leg 1: Payden's Port → Thin Shore Seed:

Valewood ♠ (Green lane), Mistlands ♥ (Protectorate clerk), Mistlands ♣ (bell failure), Mistlands ♦ (Lantern writ).

Leg 2: Thin Shore transit Seed:

Valewood ♠ (Unfound stile), Valewood ♥ (Path-warden), Valewood ♣ (Sweet wind), Valewood ♦ (Way-cord).

Rule of 9s applies.

2.7.4 Frontier Mediation (Ykrul ↔ Vilikari)

Leg: Foedus Stone parley Seed:

Vilikari ♠ (Foedus Stone), Ykrul ♥ (Noyan envoy), Wilds ♣ (rasputitsa), Vilikari ♦ (Foedus Renewal).

Blend: also draw a Ykrul ♦ (Paiza). Choose which law saves your schedule.

2.7.5 Worked Itinerary: Thin Shore → Zakov → Theona (Corsair Jobs)

Leg 1: Payden's Port → Thin Shore (Shadow Corridor) Seed:

Valewood ♠ (Green lane / Unfound stile); Mistlands ♥ (Protectorate clerk); Mistlands ♣ (bell-line failure); Mistlands ♦ (Lantern Writ).

Clock: 6. *Rule of 9s*: any 9 adds an omission.

Leg 2: Thin Shore Transit (Skirting toward Zakov) Seed:

Valewood ♠ (Sea-mist arcade); Valewood ♥ (Path-warden); Valewood ♣ (Sweet wind); Valewood ♦ (Way-cord).

Clock: 6. *Note*: spending *Way-cord* negates one *Sweet wind* lie.

Leg 3: Approach to Zakov (Roadstead & Booms) Seed:

Zakov ♠ (Boomhouse or Red Wharf); Zakov ♥ (Pilot-Matron or Night Magistrate); Zakov ♣ (Boom Drop or Customs Sweep); Zakov ♦ (Harbor-Green Chit or Pilot Token).

Clock: 6–8 (apply the Gatekeepers overlay draw on arrival). If a 9 shows: *Missing Ninth*—remove one critical step/name until paid in favors.

Leg 4: Corsair Job Inside Zakov (Pick 1) A) Lift a Hull from Drydock Four:

Zakov ♠ (Drydock Four); Zakov ♥ (Corsair Quartermaster); Zakov ♣ (Admiralty Audit); Zakov ♦ (Shipwright's Lien Release).

Goal: tow a seized hull at night; *Lien Release* avoids bond but flips a debt later.

B) Court the Black Bishop for Indulgence:

Zakov ♠ (Black Bell Tower); Zakov ♥ (Black Bishop); Zakov ♣ (Bounty Proclamation); Zakov ♦ (Magistrate's Hush).

Goal: seal a case/docket so a rival can't use it. Hook: rumor must be paid (coin or gossip).

C) Smuggler's Ladder Run:

Zakov ♠ (Lantern Ladder); Zakov ♥ (Lampman); Zakov ♣ (Informant Flip); Zakov ♦ (Smuggler's Ladder Map).

Goal: bypass boom eyes with a wall-stair. Complication: your tip was sold twice.

Leg 5: Zakov → Theona (Isles & Moot) Seed:

Theona ♠ (Uncounted Bridge); Theona ♥ (Matron of Wells or Moot Envoy); Linn ♣ (fogfall raids); Theona ♦ (Moot Token).

Clock: 6–8. Taboo: do *not* count the steps aloud; breaking it imposes *Controlled* on all isle bargains this scene.

Leg 6: Theona Contract (Pick 1) A) Raid-Truce at the Skerries:

Theona ♠ (Tide caves); Theona ♥ (Isle Moot Envoy); Theona ♣ (Muster drum); Theona ♦ (Raid-truce Ribbon).

Goal: secure safe passage window; failure triggers a Linn muster clock.

B) Deliver the Ledger Shard:

Theona ♠ (Well-yard); Theona ♥ (Matron of Wells); Zakov ♣ (Debt Call follows you); Theona ♦ (Sanctuary Night).

Goal: hide a Zakov debt long enough to copy data; sanctuary buys time.

2.7.6 Steppe Passage: Black Banner Territory

Leg: Foedus Stone → Black Banner Camp Seed:

Ykrul/Vilikari ♠ (Wolf Road milepost or Foedus Stone); Black Banner ♥ (Clan Elder or War Captain); Wilds ♣ (Rasputitsa or Remount Sickness); Black Banner ♦ (Safe-conduct or Remount Chit).

Clock: 6–8. Complication: Foedus recall may invalidate your papers.

Leg: Black Banner Camp → Ykrul Territory Seed:

Ykrul ♠ (Winter camp ring or Khagan's way-station); Ykrul ♥ (Khatun of the Ring or Noyan envoy); Frontier ♣ (Hostage protocol or Feud spark); Ykrul ♦ (Paiza tablet or Foedus seal).

Clock: 6–8. *Note*: Choose which law applies—Black Banner customs or Ykrul traditions.

2.8 Pace, Clocks, and Consequences

- Road/river leg: 6-segment clock; +2 segments if crossing a law boundary (new passports, new prayers).
- Sea strait/mountain pass: 8-segment clock; −2 segments if you spend a $\diamond$ that codifies priority (pilotage, pass, convoy).
- Shadow corridor: 6-segment clock; on any A, add a free omen to echo later.
- Failure defaults: delay (lose time; an enemy advances), diversion (alternate route; new $\clubsuit$), or debt (promise, fine, or favor owed to the authority that controls the gate).

SB Note. Re-rolling 1s does *not* erase their SB; any new 1s on the re-roll add more SB.

2.9 Story Beat (SB) Menus

2.9.1 Universal SB Spend Menu

- **1 SB** — Shave time/position: add +1 segment to the current clock *or* drop Position one step *or* impose a small fee/toll *or* mark 1 step of *Asset Exposure*.
- **2 SB** — Escalate the pressure: upgrade the active $\clubsuit$ (e.g., “inspection” → “seizure attempt”) *or* force a *choice of Diamonds* (pick which law you’ll be judged by) *or* tick a relevant *Front* by 1.
- **3 SB** — Lock a gate/taboo: close a route (boom drops; pass closes) until a named $\diamond$ is spent *or* invoke a regional taboo (Theona/Valewood 9s; oath backlash) with teeth *or* auto-trigger a *Debt Flip* on a Diamond already in play.
- **4+ SB** — Reshape the leg: rewrite the route (Aeler under-way reroute; sea lane reversal), start a *new* 4–6 segment complication clock *and* tick a *Front* by +1; demand immediate payment on a Patron/Asset Exposure (lose it if refused).

End-of-leg conversion (optional): Unspent SB convert to *world motion* at a rate of **3 SB** → **tick 1 Front** (GM choice).

2.9.2 Sea (Amaranthine/Dolmis/Aberderrin)

- **1 SB:** Fogfall nips visibility; DV +1 for the next pilotage check.
- **2 SB:** Boom shifts; pilot required (spend a *pilotage* $\diamond$ or delay +2 segments).
- **3 SB:** Lantern-law change mid-leg; choose: pay fine *or* reroute clock +2 *or* spend *Convoy Letter*.
- **4 SB:** Squall wall: split the convoy; lose an escort unless *Moot token* or *Escort* Diamond is spent.

2.9.3 Passes & Underways (Aeler)

- **1 SB:** White wind; breath-time check (mark Fatigue or slow +1 segment).
- **2 SB:** Engineer requisition; surrender cargo slot *or* coin *or* DV +1 until the gate.
- **3 SB:** Under-audit; must go below (swap $\spadesuit$ to Aeler) unless you spend *Key-Writ*.
- **4 SB:** Cave-in detour adds a fresh 4-segment clock unless *Underway Pass* is spent.

2.9.4 Rivers (Belworth & friends)

- **1 SB:** Sandbar drift; portage a beat or pay for a tow.
- **2 SB:** Lift strike at Tarlington; need *Bridge/Portage Pass* or delay +2 segments.
- **3 SB:** Cross-mouth embargo (Marcott/Fairport); choose which harbor’s law applies (draw/commit its $\diamond$).
- **4 SB:** Ice-break or flood surge; split cargo (random item at risk) unless an *Escort Diamond* is spent.

2.9.5 Shadow Corridors (Valewood/Mistlands)

- **1 SB:** Bell-line stutter; next guidance roll at Disadvantage (or DV +1).
- **2 SB:** Omission manifests; something necessary is “missing” until *Ward-salt* or *Way-cord* is spent.
- **3 SB:** Host-law claims you as *host/guest*; accept a service clock or pay with a memory (lose a minor Contact until end of leg).
- **4 SB:** Wraith procession crosses your path; create a 6-segment *Don’t Look Back* clock; spending *Lantern Writ* downgrades it to 4.

2.9.6 Steppe Frontiers (Ykrul/Vilikari/Black Banner)

- **1 SB:** Remount fatigue; lose 1 “fresh mount” use or slow +1 segment.
- **2 SB:** Hostage protocol; must place/accept a token-kin until the next gate (or spend *Safe-hostage*).
- **3 SB:** Foedus recall; your papers conflict—pick Ykrul *Paiza* or Vilikari *Foedus Seal* and offend the other.
- **4 SB:** Muster checkpoint; disarm unless traveling under *Standard Protection* or *Khagan’s Writ*.
- **Black Banner Specific:** Clan feud erupts; choose sides or pay double tolls.

2.9.7 Ports & Forums (Marcott, Fairport, Silkstrand, Thepyrgos, Zakov)

- **1 SB:** Clerk error; pay a “stamp” fee or answer questions (DV +1).
- **2 SB:** Rival petition; they jump the queue unless you spend a Warrant/Letters $\diamond$.
- **3 SB:** Audit cascade; open a new 4-segment *Inspection* clock tied to cargo/ledger.
- **4 SB:** Edict flare; convert today’s $\clubsuit$ into a temporary “law” everyone must obey or take on a *Debt Flip*.
- **Zakov Specific:** Silent Court ruling; legal $\clubsuit$ escalate by +1 SB.

2.9.8 Diamond & Exposure Interactions

- **2 SB:** Flip any $\diamond$ spent this leg: its *Debt Flip* is collected now (not later).
- **2 SB:** Mark 1 step on a named Asset/Patron’s *Exposure* track.
- **3 SB:** Downgrade an *Intricate* success to *Detailed* (remove the flourish or DV 1 benefit).
- **4 SB:** Seize or suspend a visible Diamond’s benefit until another is played (e.g., convoy letter overridden by emergency edict).

Part II

The Northern Shore

Chapter 3

Kahfagia

The Empire of Wakes and Storm-Flags. Kahfagia is a maritime power whose strength lies not in territory but in control of the sea lanes. The Lantern-Law, administered by the Admiral of Lantern-Law, governs every beacon, boom, and berth. Pilots carry mirrors that speak in code, and the spice auctions of Kassamira set prices across the Amaranthine. To sail under Kahfagia's protection is to move with the tide; to defy it is to find the beacons turned against you.

3.1 Kahfagia — “The Creole Thalassocracy”

Quick Reference

Tagline: *Every mirror is a blade, every beacon a promise. The sea obeys when we move the lights — but the spiders weave in the mirror-towers.*

Admiral of Lantern-Law (Elite): “Every mirror is a blade, every beacon a promise. The sea obeys when we move the lights — and woe to the fool who rows against them. Yet I have seen the reflection move before the hand that holds it. The tides are not the only ones with secrets.”

Dockside Factor (Commoner): “The pilots see farther than kings. A gesture in lantern-code can open ports, or close them. Keep your debts paid, and your lamps trimmed. And if a grey-robed stranger offers to adjust your mirror for free — say no. The Lethai-ar have long memories, and longer webs.”

Genre / Mood: Creole thalassocracy, signal-and-lane politics, eldritch tide, secret infiltration.

Starting Location: The Lantern Pier admiralty chapel, where votive ships hang from the ceiling and brine drips from the icon of a drowned saint. A sea-notary unlocks a salt-stained reliquary and produces a chart with gilt edges. “Fetch the contraband bell from the corsair galleass *Santa Dolorosa* before moonrise — or the harbour names you accomplices. And watch for silk threads on the bollards. The Spider's children are everywhere.”

Theme & Atmosphere

Kahfagia is the Creole child of Oshiira and the Vilikari — a thalassocracy where Oshiiran ledgers meet Vilikari tide-law. The Admiralty of Lantern-Law rules not by armies but by light, yet the real power flows through a tangled web of oligarchic families, each with their own spies, their own private navies, and their own seat on the Shadow Council. Above them all floats a central Admiralty fleet, charged with protecting the beacon monopoly — and with watching the watchers.

But the oligarchs are not the only players. Unseen, the Lethai-ar of Inaea have been infiltrating the mirror-towers for decades. A factor's trusted secretary, a harbour master's silent wife, a pilot's apprentice with too-still eyes — they weave their webs not for coin, but for *control*. They do not seek to destroy Kahfagia. They seek to *own* it, strand by strand, until the entire thalassocracy hums to the rhythm of the Spider's mercy.

What you notice first: The constant chime of bell-buoys. The smell of salt, tar, and burnt oil from a thousand lanterns. The way everyone — admiral to dockhand — glances at the tide clock before speaking. And the faint, almost invisible silk threads tied around the bollards of the wealthiest piers.

The one rule that kills newcomers: Never argue with a Mirror-Keeper about where the channel lies. If they say the safe water moved, it moved. Your chart is already kindling. And if the Mirror-Keeper smiles too widely, check the back of their neck for a spider's brand.

Regional Mood: The Lantern's Vigil & The Spider's Web

Power is visible here — literally. Every night, a thousand lamps burn along the channels, each a statement of control. To dim a light is to declare bankruptcy. To move a beacon is to declare war. Commodores sit in their mirror-towers, watching reflections, while tide-clocks tick down to the next auction, the next inspection, the next quiet murder.

But beneath the visible power, another war is fought in whispers. The Lethai-ar agents of Inaea have spent a generation infiltrating the oligarchic families. A young heir who suddenly displays uncanny negotiating skill may not be talented — they may be *woven*. A Mirror-Keeper whose beacons never fail may be receiving guidance from a source that does not appear on any chart. The Spider's web is patient. It does not break the thalassocracy; it *guides* it.

Prominent NPCs of Kahfagia

Name	Role/Title	Motivation	Rumoured Quirk
Admiral Zafira	Commander of Lantern-Law	Keep the beacon monopoly intact	She has never lost a ship to the reefs. Her charts are said to be drawn in water.

Mirza al-Qasr	Mirror-Keeper of the Pointe	Control the tides through light	Her face is never seen—only reflected. Some say she has no shadow.
Ximena	Dockside Factor (commoner exemplar)	Profit from every cargo, legal or not	She keeps a ledger in lemon juice; heat reveals the truth.
Captain Rodrigo	Privateer with a crooked letter of marque	Raid the corsair fleet and pay off his crew	His ship flies three flags; the one he lowers last is the one that matters.
Sister Anabel	Healer of the Hospitallers of the Salted Veil (Temple of Light)	Tend the sick without asking payment	Her grey robes are said to be woven from old debts. They never stain.
Notary Farid	Admiralty magistrate	Resolve disputes before they reach the harbour master	He carries a water-clock in his sleeve to measure the shifting of legal moods.
The Veiled Harpist	Lethai-ar infiltrator (secret)	Woven the oligarchs, strand by strand	No one knows her face. She plays only in mirror-lit rooms, and her music leaves threads of silk in the listeners’ hair.

The Oligarchic Houses (Shadow Council)

The true rulers of Kahfagia are not the Admiralty alone, but the **Shadow Council** of seven oligarchic families. Each controls a monopoly (spice, salt, silk, timber, pitch, shipbuilding, or intelligence). Each maintains its own private navy and network of spies. Each vies for the empty seat left by the family that the Lethai-ar have already *woven* into silence.

- **House al-Kassam (Spice):** Oldest, proudest, most vulnerable. The Lethai-ar have already

replaced the family steward.

- **House Carrasco (Salt):** Ruthless pragmatists; they suspect infiltration but cannot prove it.
- **House Mirat (Silk):** Secret allies of the Lethai-ar — they trade webs for influence.
- **House del Puerto (Shipbuilding):** Neutral; they build for anyone who pays.
- **House Henares (Timber):** Deeply indebted to the Admiralty; the Lethai-ar are slowly buying their notes.
- **House de la Vela (Intelligence):** The Admiralty’s own spy network — and already compromised.
- **The Empty Chair:** Once held by House Morat, now vacant. The other houses whisper that the Morats were not destroyed — they were *rewoven*.

Secret Faction: The Silk Vigil (Lethai-ar Infiltrators)

Agents of Inaea, the Spider’s children have spent a generation worming into Kahfagia’s elite. They do not steal or sabotage — they *guide*. A decision that benefits House Carrasco is subtly nudged toward the Lethai-ar’s long-term goal: a unified thalassocracy that answers not to the Admiralty, but to the Web.

Signs of Infiltration:

- A factor’s handwriting becomes unnaturally precise, the loops forming faint eight-shapes.
- A Mirror-Keeper’s reflections show the same face in every tower — a woman with chestnut-brown skin and eyes like polished jet.
- A ship that should have foundered instead limps to port, its crew speaking of a grey-robed passenger who vanished before docking.

Mechanical Hook: Once per session, a PC may roll Wits + Lore (DV 4) to notice a silken thread in an official’s collar or a spider’s brand on a dockhand’s wrist. On success, they identify a Lethai-ar agent. On failure, the agent becomes aware of their scrutiny — and the Web tightens.

Names of Kahfagia

Inspired by the sea-faring republics of the western coast, blended with Oshiiran and Vilikari influences: liquid consonants, soft vowels, and surnames that denote a port, a ship, or a founding ancestor.

First Names (Male)	First Names (Female)	Surnames	Epithets
Safir	Zafira	al-Kassam	<i>the Lantern</i>
Idris	Ximena	del Puerto	<i>Tide-Keeper</i>
Farid	Layla	de la Vela	<i>the Unlit</i>
Jabir	Aisha	Carrasco	<i>Mirror-Eye</i>
Rodrigo	Salma	Mirat	<i>Bell-Born</i>
Tarik	Nura	Henares	<i>Ash-Sails</i>

Spades — Places (Littoral/Lane/Law)

2. **Tidal Mudflat** — Hidden plank-way at low water; smugglers’ shortcut. *At ebb, the planks rise like the ribs of a drowned whale.* ‘[STEALTH]’

3. **Salt-Scar Pier** — Behind dawn spice auctions; where fortunes wash ashore. *Auditors check the salt-scars — white crust that proves cargo was cleaned, not stolen.* ‘[TRADE]’
4. **Reedbelt Creeks** — Smuggler paths where tax boats won’t follow. *A hanged man’s boots hang from a piling; those who pass tug their collars.* ‘[STEALTH]’
5. **Breakwater Gap** — Under repair; cutters slip at dusk through the works. *The stone is still loose. A wrong step, and the sea claims another toll.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
6. **Dredged Channel** — Fresh with temporary beacons; tomorrow’s safe water. *The buoys are painted yellow — the colour of “maybe.”* ‘[TRAVEL]’
7. **River Sluice** — Tide-gate and boom-chain; access controlled by rope and writ. *The chain has a notch where a slaver’s ship tried to flee. It still drips oil.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
8. **Cutter Yard** — Narrow-keel vessels; apprentices work night shifts. *They sing old work songs — the kind that skip the ninth beat.* ‘[LABOR]’
9. **Lantern Alley** — Fog-lane where beacons migrate with the tide. *Follow the lights. Two blinks means you’re expected. Three? You’re prey.* ‘[WEATHER]’
10. **Admiralty Quay** — Bonded warehouses under seal; law walks the decks. *The seal on the door changes with the tide. Today it’s a serpent eating its tail.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- J **Red Shoal** — Quiet water, loud reputations; where deals are made. *Old barges moored together; a floating court with no bailiff.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
- Q **Mirror Tower** — Pilot station that certifies safe water — today. *The mirror at the top shows not the sea, but the face of the last captain who argued.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
- K **Kassamira Port** — Presidial; auctions at dawn, courts by noon. *The auctioneer’s gavel is wrapped in a page torn from a debtor’s ledger.* ‘[TRADE]’
- A **The Pointe** — Strait of storm-lights and wreckers’ tales. *On still nights, you can hear the drowned singing the names of those who owe.* ‘[DEATH]’

Hearts — People & Factions

2. **Tide-Runner** — Bell and rope; knows every tide-table by heart. *“The table says high water at noon. The moon lies. Trust my rope.”* ‘[TRAVEL]’
3. **Pilot’s Apprentice** — Perfect memory for shoals; tomorrow’s navigator. *Touches a brass talisman before every sounding. No one knows why.* ‘[TRAVEL]’
4. **Lantern Clerk** — Knows which lights moved, and why; keeper of the shifts. *Docks with a ledger that smells of smoke. Adds a surcharge for “recent adjustments.”* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
5. **Oshiiran Factor** — Two ledgers; one for Kahfagia, one for truth. *The left ledger records bribes as “conciliation fees.” The right one is never shown.* ‘[TRADE]’
6. **Dock-Syndic** — Makes queues vanish; power in the pause. *He never raises his voice. The harbour master listens anyway.* ‘[SOCIAL]’
7. **Lantern Advocate** — “Jurisdiction moves like tide”; law in flux. *She carries a water-clock in her sleeve to measure the shifting of legal moods.* ‘[JUSTICE]’
8. **Privateer Captain** — “Crooked” letter of convoy; profit in the margins. *Her ship flies three flags; the one she lowers last is the one that matters.* ‘[COMBAT]’
9. **Thalassoi Sergeant** — Shore leave but still on duty; marine precision. *A tattoo of a lighthouse on his forearm; the light is his wife’s name.* ‘[COMBAT]’
10. **Admiralty Magistrate** — Rules fast, travels faster; justice in a hurry. *She once sentenced a man to the galleys and boarded the ship before he did.* ‘[JUSTICE]’

- J **Dredging Foreman** — Channel follows their purse; water reshaped. *His crew are ex-criminals; he pays them in salt pork and absolution.* ‘[LABOR]’
- Q **Mirror-Keeper (Elite)** — Commodore’s confidante; places beacons that bind. *Their faces are never seen — only reflected. Some say they have none.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- K **Kahfagian Commodore** — Off the books but on the water; shadow admiral. *His flagship is a fishing smack. Its nets drag up letters of marque.* ‘[AUTHORITY]’
- A **Admiral of Red Shoal** — Offers wine, figs — once. Price in stories. *She pours the first cup herself. If she pours a second, you’ve already agreed.* ‘[LEGEND]’

Clubs — Complications/Threats

(Entries unchanged except for the addition of a new threat: **Web Unravelled** – a Lethai-ar agent is exposed, and the oligarchs turn on each other.)

2. **Early Tide** — Turns two bells early; grounding risk rises like the sea. ‘[WEATHER]’ *Someone bribed the tide-clerk — or the moon is angry.*
 3. **Smothering Fog** — Sound travels, sight does not; navigation by ear alone. ‘[WEATHER]’ *You hear oars. Then you don’t. Then they’re behind you.*
 4. **Boom Slam** — Harbour chain slams shut; wrong side means delay or danger. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The chain’s links are inscribed with names of debtors. Each one rattles differently.*
 5. **Light Shift** — Beacons change mid-approach; your lane just moved. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *Someone paid the Lantern Clerk. Find out who — or drift into the reefs.*
 6. **Pilot Strike** — No escorts available; average unpaid, risk assumed. ‘[LABOR]’ *The pilots sit in their guildhall, drinking tea, watching ships founder.*
 7. **Customs Inspection** — Ladder audits cargo and crew; delays bite deep. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The inspector has a silver tooth. He smiles when he sees a manifest.*
 8. **Reef-Runners** — Corsair skiffs circle with boarding hooks; steel in the spray. ‘[COMBAT]’ *Their leader wears a Mirror-Keeper’s badge — stolen or earned, you cannot tell.*
 9. **Jurisdiction Flip** — Lantern-law shifts; your writ no longer bites. ‘[JUSTICE]’ *The tide turned. So did the magistrate. Your safe-conduct is now kindling.*
 10. **Fire Risk** — Alchemical cargo aboard; quarantine if anything spills. ‘[DISASTER]’ *A single spark and the whole quay becomes a crater. The factor wants you to know this.*
- J **Quartermaster Betrayal** — Tide-tables sold to rival; route compromised. ‘[SOCIAL]’ *The betrayal is written in lemon juice; heat reveals the name.*
- Q **Yellow Flag** — Port quarantine; deadlines rot on the hook. ‘[DEATH]’ *The flag is dyed with turmeric and something else — something that smells sweet.*
- K **Fleet Redeploy** — “Safe” corridor becomes parade ground; chaos in formation. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *Admirals play chess with real ships, and you are a pawn.*
- A **Black Squall (at the Pointe)** — Scatters ships and stories alike. ‘[WEATHER]’ ‘[DEATH]’ *This is no natural storm. The water hisses. Something below is waking.*
- + **Web Unravelled** — A Lethai-ar agent is exposed. The oligarchs turn on each other, accusing every rival of being a spider. ‘[POLITICS]’ ‘[FEAR]’ *Silk threads appear on every doorknob. No one trusts their shadow.*

Diamonds — Rewards/Leverage

(Unchanged; the existing rewards work well for a thalassocracy.)

2. **Mooring Chit** — Skip the Mooring Roll once; harbour favours you. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The chit is a dried seahorse shell. Keep it away from salt.*
 3. **Pilotage Token** — One certified escort through a bad channel. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The pilot who accepts it must touch your shoulder before speaking.*
 4. **Fee Waiver** — Cargo cleared today; ledger smiles included. ‘[TRADE]’ *The clerk stamps it twice — once for the crown, once for the Hollow.*
 5. **Safe-Conduct** — Along specific beacons lane; law walks with you. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *The commodore’s seal is warm. It cools as the exit nears.*
 6. **Salvage Rights** — On named quay or reach; flotsam becomes fortune. ‘[TRADE]’ *You must name each piece before touching it. The wrong word forfeits the claim.*
 7. **Warehouse Access** — Bonded storage; seal prize before rivals sniff. ‘[TRADE]’ *The key is a bronze finger. It fits only one lock — and breaks after use.*
 8. **Lantern Code** — Tonight’s signals revealed; navigation advantage. ‘[TRAVEL]’ *Three quick flashes: safe passage. One long, two short: the Admiralty is watching.*
 9. **Dredging Grant** — You decide where next channel runs; reshape the sea. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The dredgers are convicts. They work faster if you promise a name in their favour.*
 10. **Letter of Marque** — Convoy protection for one season; legal blades. ‘[COMBAT]’ *The ink is mixed with gunpowder. It smokes slightly when read.*
- J **Admiralty Judgment** — Precedent travels with you; law bends. ‘[JUSTICE]’ *The case number is burned into a leather tag. Tag it to a belt loop.*
- Q **Mirror Warrant** — Legal right to post a beacon; redraw the map. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The Mirror-Keeper’s seal, still warm. The channel you mark becomes law — until challenged.*
- K **Spice Share** — Stake in Kassamira auction floor; profit in pepper. ‘[TRADE]’ *The share is a peppercorn sealed in wax. Bite it to test authenticity.*
- A **Lantern License** — Temporary authority to redefine the lane. ‘[AUTHORITY]’ *The harbour master spits when he hands it over. Use it wisely — or not at all.*

Quick use notes

- Draw until you have all four suits: Spade = place, Heart = actor, Club = pressure, Diamond = leverage. Highest rank sets the main Clock (2–5 → 4, 6–10 → 6, J/Q/K → 8, A → 10).
- Diamonds are codified outcomes (papers/rights/priority) that change position rather than call for a roll.
- If any A appears, echo **sea & signal** motifs — beacons that migrate, tides that remember, law that flows like water. If a King or Ace of Spades appears, also echo **web motifs** — silk threads on a bollard, a reflection that holds too long, the faint smell of spiced tea (the Lethai-ar are near).

Additional Features (Cultural Mechanics)

- **Pilot’s Mirror:** Kahfagia’s strength is not its fleet but its monopoly on light and lane. To post a beacon is to redraw the map. Any character with a Mirror Warrant may permanently move a beacon or buoy (GM sets a 4-segment clock). For the duration of that clock, all

navigation rolls on that lane are at +1 Position for the party and −1 Position for rivals.

- **Lantern-Law Privilege:** While flying an Admiralty flag or carrying a valid Lantern License, your ship may pass through chain-booms and customs points at +1 Position. The first time in a session you invoke this privilege, the GM gains 1 SB (the Admiralty is watching).
- **Oligarchic Favour (Leverage Track):** Instead of tracking coin debts, track *Favour* with the great families (al-Kassam, Carrasco, Mirat, etc.). Favour 1–3 gives you access to private docks, early auction warnings, and off-the-books pilots. Favour 4+ lets you call in a family to block a rival’s safe-conduct or raise a false alarm on their ship.
- **The Web’s Patience (Secret Clock [6]):** Tracks the Lethai-ar infiltration of the Shadow Council. The clock ticks when the party helps a Lethai-ar agent, exposes a rival house’s secrets, or ignores a silken thread. At 3, the Harpist’s name appears on a dockmaster’s manifest. At 6, the Empty Chair is filled — and the new house head bows to a grey-robed stranger. The party may reduce the clock by exposing an agent or by warning an oligarch (costs Favour 2).
- **Western Reach Rumours:** Once per port visit, a character may roll Wits + Lore (DV 3) to hear a rumour from a captain returned from beyond the mirror. On success, the GM reveals one of the six rumours (see below) as a foreshadowing hook or a clue for an ongoing arc.
- **Local Patrons (Syncretic Names):**
 - **The Lantern Bearer** — The Traveler. *A light that never goes out; a promise that never sinks.*
 - **The Mirror-King** — The Witness. *Reflections that remember every lie, every promise, every cargo.*
 - **The Tide Father** — Khemesh. *The pressure beneath the keel; the debt that the sea collects at ebb.*
 - **The Spider’s Daughter** — Inaea (secret). *The web that binds the oligarchs, strand by patient strand.*
 - **The Unlit** — Ikasha. *The ninth lamp that is never lit; the safe harbour that exists only in rumour.*

Lore Echoes (Cross-Expansion Hooks)

- **Saint Alvaro of the Lantern (The Traveler):** The Admiralty’s mirror-towers double as wayshrines for the Saint of Lost Channels. Sailors who light a candle before a voyage and whisper a destination to the mirror claim the tide will not turn against them before they reach it. The Mirror-Keepers charge a fee for this service — payable in salt, not silver.
- **The Silken Coup (Inaea):** The Lethai-ar call their infiltration the *Genteel Harvest*. They do not conquer; they adopt. An oligarch who accepts a grey-robed advisor finds that their children are betrothed to shadow-kin, their ledgers are copied in disappearing ink, and their mirror-tower shows only the face they wish to see — not the one that watches them sleep.
- **The Tide-Sworn Compact (The Admiral of Sealed Tides):** A small but influential order of notaries based in Kassamira Port. They adjudicate disputes over beacon rights, cargo claims, and pilotage fees. Their judgments are always delivered in triplicate, and they accept no bribes — only binding oaths. Those who lie before a Covenant judge find that their next three voyages are plagued by contrary winds.
- **The Hospitallers of the Salted Veil (The Bitter Root):** A hospice on Deadman’s Quay is run by grey-robed healers of the Order. They ask no payment, but they never forget a face. It is said that if you accept their care, you owe a favour to the sea itself — and the sea always

collects. Smugglers leave small offerings of fresh water on the pier to stay in the Order’s good graces.

- **The Ninth:** In any lantern-lit scene, the ninth lamp lit in a room reveals a threshold. The wise stop at eight. Those who light the ninth are said to see a figure standing on the water outside the window — waiting.

Kahfagia Superstitions (burn for +1 die once)

- **Bread to the Wake:** Toss a crust over your shoulder before entering a new channel. Ignore the first *Smothering Fog* penalty. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Turn the Lantern:** Spin the binnacle lamp once counter-clockwise. Cancel *Boom Slam* or take –1 die on your next pilot check (your choice). ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Name to the Deep:** Whisper a true name into a lead line. Gain +1 Effect against corsairs for the scene, but mark *Obligation* to the Tide Court. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’
- **Cut the Thread:** If you find a silk thread on your bollard, cut it with a silver knife. Negate the next *Web’s Patience* tick. ‘[SUPERSTITION]’

Thematic SB Spend Table

(Unchanged; see earlier table.)

Western Reach Rumours (d6, fast hooks)

1. A harbour where bells toll under water; cargo *must* be named aloud.
2. A spice that stops bleeding — until moonrise.
3. A mirror-reef that reflects storms from a week ahead.
4. A pilotage guild that uses birds, not beacons.
5. A fleet that sails by *shadow* cast on fog.
6. A court that weighs debts in *breath*, not coin.

Pursuit Ladder (Near / Mid / Far)

- **Advance/Withdraw (Sail + Wits):** On a hit, shift one band. On a strong hit, also impose *Wake Surge*.
- **Cut the Lane (Pilot + Tactics):** On a hit, freeze range for one exchange; if a beacon is under your colour, +1 die.
- **Weather the Squall (Resolve + Sail):** On a hit in *Black Squall*, you pick who drifts; on a miss, the Keeper does.

Boss Seeds (Sea & Signal / Web & Silk)

- **The Mirror-Keeper of Kassamira (signal tyrant)** — *Phases:* Audit → Blacklist → Light Embargo. *Cracks:* rival beacon logs, Tide Court precedent, stolen codebook.
- **Corsair-Chaplain of the Pointe (relic raider)** — *Phases:* Charm → Board → Bell-Wake. *Cracks:* sanctified boom, cofradía oath, drowned-saint tithe.
- **The Veiled Harpist (Spider’s Daughter)** — *Phases:* Whisper → Weave → Harvest. *Cracks:* speak a true name of a Lethai-ar agent, cut a strand of the Web with silver, or remind an oligarch of a debt older than the Spider’s memory.

Patronage & Power

In Kahfagia, power flows through control of the sea lanes themselves — and through the silken threads that bind the oligarchs to the Spider's will. The maritime oligarchs have built their empire not through conquest of territory but through mastery of navigation and the quiet manipulation of debt. Every beacon, every channel marker, every mirror-light is both a navigational aid and a legal instrument. But behind every mirror, a grey-robed woman watches. And she is very, very patient.

For the GM: Kahfagian patronage revolves around access — to channels, to cargo, to legal protection. Rewards often take the form of pilotage tokens, safe-conducts, or salvage rights. But the secret war of the Lethai-ar adds a new layer: players may be hired to expose an agent, to protect an oligarch from being "woven," or even to ally with the Spider's children for a share of the Harvest. Use the **Web's Patience** clock to track the infiltration; let players decide whether to slow it, accelerate it, or ride it to power.